

Counting Mangos

“...Twenty one, then?”

“Mmm, I count twenty three.”

“Impossible, those two are dead.”

“You always count the dead ones.”

“No you don’t.”

“You do,” she says. “As long as they are still on the tree.”

“Yes, but you don’t eat the dead ones,” I explain.

“Sure, but they are still there.”

“You’re impossible.”

We pick twenty one mangos, leaving the two dead ones. In a canvas bag we take them along the shore, the waves rolling in, tipping over and crashing past the reef.

“Would you count dead horses?” I ask.

“Now, why would I do that?”

She laughs and takes a mango from the bag, prying it open, tearing the meat from the seed. She eats the flesh from the skin and discards it along with the seed into the ocean. The white mast of a sailboat cuts the blue water.

“Would you count that one?” I ask, pointing the mango remains rising in the swash.

“Which one?”

“The one you just ate. Does that make it twenty or twenty one?”

“I said there were twenty three.”

I start to argue but she takes my hand.

“Darling, you’re much too concerned by the fine discrepancies. These things are just ideas made up by us. What we choose to concern ourselves with is exactly what our lives become. Is your life really on that cares if you count dead mangos?”

Off shore, a strong wind fills the sail and the boat capsizes. Young men jump from the cabin into the bright water. One swims to the hull and stands on the exposed keel. The others join and swim the ropes out. They heave and the mast lifts from the water, the sea raining down from the wet cloth. The sailboat swings upright.

The sun and the white and the blue and the clouds. The men climb aboard, whipping back their wet hair. We can hear them cheer from the shore.

“No,” I say at last.

She takes another mango from the canvas and begins to peel it with her nails.

“Then be a good darling and stop all that talking.”